



The Sitcom Syllabus: Five Steaks and an Eggplant

Learn real-world English vocabulary,
90s culture, and restaurant etiquette
through a classic television episode.

Two Stories. One Big Misunderstanding.

This episode revolves around two main conflicts:



1. **The Income Gap:** Three friends make good money. Three friends do not. A birthday dinner forces them to finally talk about it.
2. **The Wrong Number:** A woman named Jade calls the wrong apartment looking for Bob. Chandler decides to pretend he is Bob to get a date.

The Income Gap Matrix

The High Earners
(Ross, Monica, Chandler)

Career: Paleontologist, Head Lunch Chef, IT Procurement.

Attitude: I just never think of money as an issue.

Action: Casually order expensive seafood (Carpaccio, Grilled Prawns, Cajun Catfish).

The Struggling Earners
(Rachel, Phoebe, Joey)

Career: Waitress, Masseuse, Struggling Actor.

Attitude: Forced to calculate what a kidney sells for.

Action: Order the absolute minimum (Side Salad, \$4 Cucumber Soup).

Key Vocabulary

Income Gap (noun) - A difference in the amount of money people earn.



The Cost of Dining Out

When the group goes to the fancy restaurant PhilloSophie to celebrate Monica's promotion, the prices shock half the table.

Vocabulary Spotlight:

Steep (adjective): Very expensive. (Chandler: Look guys, I know it's a little steep.)

Cha-ching (slang): The sound a cash register makes; used to describe something that costs a lot of money. (Rachel: Yeah, these are pretty cha-ching.)



Cultural Context: Splitting the Check

When the bill arrives, Ross calculates the total, adds the tip, and divides it evenly by six. He asks everyone to pay \$33.50. Phoebe refuses, because her soup only cost \$4.00.

Vocabulary Spotlight:

- **Split the check** (verb phrase): To divide a restaurant bill equally among everyone at the table, regardless of what individuals ordered.
- **Pay for what you had** (verb phrase): To calculate exactly what you ate and drank and only pay that specific amount.



The Birthday Hoopla

Trying to fix the tension, the wealthier friends buy everyone tickets to a Hootie and the Blowfish concert. It backfires. The gesture makes the other three feel small.

Vocabulary Spotlight:

Hoopla (noun): Excitement, noise, or unnecessary fuss surrounding an event.

Charity (noun): Help or money given to those in need. (Joey: It just feels like charity.)

Dial things back (phrasal verb): To reduce the intensity or scale of something.



The Wrong Number

A woman named Jade leaves a message looking for her ex-boyfriend, Bob. She says she wants to hook up again. Chandler answers the phone, claims to be Bob, and arranges to meet her at Central Perk.

Vocabulary Spotlight:

Hook up (phrasal verb): Slang for becoming romantically or sexually involved with someone.

Stand someone up (idiom): To fail to meet someone for a planned date without letting them know. (Chandler tells Jade that Bob stood her up, making himself look like the sensitive stranger.)

The 1995 Tech Flowchart



The Landline:
Tied to a physical location.
Chandler intercepts
Jade's call here.



The Answering Machine:
Recording audio onto a
cassette. Chandler uses
it for screening calls
(listening to the caller
before deciding whether
to answer).



The Pager / Beeper:
A device that receives
short alerts or phone
numbers. Monica gets
a page from her boss,
Leon.

The Original Catfish

Chandler intercepts Jade at the coffee shop. When Bob doesn't show up, Chandler offers her a tissue and pretends to be a wry, sensitive stranger. He successfully deceives her into sleeping with him.

Vocabulary Spotlight:

Catfish (verb): To lure someone into a relationship by adopting a fictional online (or in this case, telephone) persona.

Wry (adjective): Using dry, mocking, or sarcastic humor.



The System Corrects Itself

Jade calls the answering machine back to leave a message for Bob about her fling with Chandler. Chandler answers, fishing for compliments, but gets demolished.

Vocabulary Spotlight:

Mediocre (adjective): Of only moderate quality; not very good. (Jade calls Chandler's performance eh).

Bumpy (adjective): Uneven or rough. Jade complains the experience was awkward and bumpy, leaving Chandler maximally humiliated.



The Five Steaks and an Eggplant

Monica brings home a luxurious dinner: five steaks, and an eggplant for Phoebe. She explains that the new meat suppliers gave them to her as a thank you. Her boss pages her shortly after.

Vocabulary Spotlight:

Kickback (noun): An illicit payment or gift made to someone in return for facilitating a business transaction.

Fired on the spot (idiom): Terminated from a job immediately, without warning.



Corporate Policy Violation



The Promotion:

Monica was recently made Head Lunch Chef and put in charge of purchasing ingredients.



The Violation:

Because she is the one who decides which meat supplier the restaurant uses, accepting a gift from them is considered a bribe.

The Result: She loses her promotion, her purchasing title, and her beeper in 30 seconds.

The Great Equalizer

The moment Monica loses her job, the money argument evaporates. Nobody cares about splitting checks when a friend is hurting.

The Irony: Joey bravely grabs the \$4.12 coffee check to pay for Monica. It is a sweet gesture, but he immediately has to turn and ask Chandler to borrow five bucks. The income gap is still there, but the friendship survives it.



Comprehension Check: True or False?

1. Rachel orders the Cajun catfish because Ross is paying.
[T / F]
2. Chandler gets away with his deception and Jade thinks he is great.
[T / F]
3. Phoebe's cucumber soup cost \$33.50. ☒
4. Monica loses her job because accepting the steak was a kickback.
[T / F]

Answers: 1.F, 2.F, 3.F, 4.T

Sitcom Discussion Prompts

Practice your English by discussing these questions with a partner or writing your answers:

- **The Check:** Do you agree with Ross (split the check evenly) or Phoebe (pay for what you had)? How does this work in your home country?
- **The Secret:** Should Chandler have told Jade the truth immediately, or was he justified in pretending to be Bob?
- **The Job:** Was Monica's boss right to fire her for accepting the steaks, even though she didn't know it was a violation?

